

VERMONT INSTITUTE OF COMMUNITY INVOLVEMENT

Opening Ceremony and Festival
September 29, 1973

In Praise of Venture

Mayor Paquette, Commissioner Withey, Dr. LaCasce, Trustees, Faculty, and Students of Vermont Institute for Community Involvement, Honored Guests and Friends...

In the Sixth book of Paradise Lost, John Milton speaks of the strange situation in which Satan marshalls his followers to prepare for battle against their fellow angels - those self same angels

"Who (were) wont to meet
So oft in Festivals of joy and love
Unanimous."

It seems to me that we have here this afternoon a delightful reversal of the angelic situation. We have here persons from our state and city governments, persons from our various educational institutions, and persons from our community not directly associated with the academic world. We are all here, each from his own compartmentalized world from which we (all too often) in this sometimes mad world of fierce competition for federal money and for power look with suspicion upon each other, anxious lest while another group gains, we might lose. And so while we too often are drawn up in battle lines against each other we are here today,

"to meet in this festival of joy and love."

unanimous in our hope that VICI will prosper and will invite us to celebrate with her the many jubilees in her future.

And it is good for us to be here on this glorious afternoon in our beautiful park in our beautiful city. It is good to be present at openings, at births, for they are signs of life. When Steward asked me to speak I was greatly honored and humbled at the thought of speaking to a crowd of worthies such as this but in the spirit of St. Paul trusted that "I can do all things in Him who strengthens me." Steward explained that the VICI community hoped that the festival this afternoon would be a joyous one and they promptly proceeded to insure that it would be by arranging for Ronald's Overture composed especially for this occasion to be played by the University's Brass Ensemble and for Peter Isaacson's Green Mountain Boy and Firefly. As I was preparing for this occasion I pondered upon the custom of having a prepared address as part of a festival of joy. Quite frankly, it did occur to me that the custom might be an atavistic desire to suffer a bit in the midst of our pleasures lest an angry God drop us into a fiery pit for being too happy. Be that as it may, I plan to do my bit this afternoon if not to add to the joyousness of the occasion, at least not to detract from it by being too ponderous. What I plan to do is not to sound forth dogmatically on education nor is it my plan to give advice. One of my favorite literary compositions is by a fourth-grader who was asked to write a composition on Socrates and in his syllagistic-like form the young student wrote:

Socrates was a philosopher,
He went around giving people advice,
The people poisoned Socrates.

No, what I want to do is merely to muse aloud this afternoon and hope that perhaps one of the thoughts I express will in the beautiful phrase of T. S. Eliot, "tease you into thought."

Would you believe because of the acronym VICI, I toyed with the idea of titling my words: Vani, Vedi, VICI. It was only a passing fancy, I assure you. Mainly because VICI to me is principally Steward LaCasce and I think of Steward as the Renaissance Man and the Renaissance leads me to Erasmus, I decided to speak today In Praise of, don't worry Steward, not folly, but In Praise of Venture. And by venture here, I mean the undertaking that involves risk, the undertaking that requires the leap of faith.

I have not heard that anyone has, but I would be completely surprised if someone hasn't, asked of the VICI family -- Why a new educational institution? Are there not enough established institutions to provide education to all who need it? These questions, it seems to me, pose the greatest challenge to the pioneer. How does he justify the expenditure of time, effort, and resources in his venture?

The obvious response to this challenge is that the true pioneer believes in his venture, believes that he is about to provide something that has not been provided before, believes that established institutions have not provided services in the same manner as he intends to provide them.

I would like to insert parenthetically here that what I say in praise of venture in no way suggest adverse criticism of our traditional institutions, one of which I proudly claim as my own. It seems to me that it is unfortunately an American custom that when we get something new, we sometimes completely destroy what the innovation replaced. The railroad is a good example of this. If we somehow could have developed air travel without dwarfing (or indeed almost annihilating) the railroads we would be happier travelers today. If in urban renewal, and I do bow to experts in this field who understand its' problems whereas I am a mere on-looker, we could preserve some of the old with the new, our young people might have less rootlessness, a greater sense of belonging. I felt optimistic as I watched the astronauts' wives in the costumes and vehicles of an earlier era go to meet their husbands after their mind-boggling odyssey in space; perhaps we are beginning to believe that the new does not replace but rather adds to the old.

And so when I praise VICI as a new venture in education I in no sense intend to impugn the old. I realize that it is the fashionable posture to denigrate our traditional colleges and universities as being citadels of fiscal mismanagement, as abysses of irrelevance, and bastions of amoral if not immoral decadence. And unfortunately our recent national tragedy in which some of our most gifted young men from our most prestigious universities quite obviously did not have the moral stamina to resist peer pressure, gave credence to the inadequacy of our educational institutions. But, should we dwell instead on what our colleges and universities have done

positively for us, we would, I am sure, be convinced that they have contributed mightily to our individual and our country's strength. Having, I trust, convinced you that I believe in the continuance of traditional education (with the reservation that the possibility within them of change for the better is great) let me turn now to this new educational venture whose opening we are celebrating today.

Statistics reveal that there are many Vermonters whose education ceases after high school. In fact we rank among the foremost of the states with great numbers of persons who have not availed themselves of post-secondary educational opportunities. That in itself is one of the prevailing reasons for our support of VICI. Let the critics say that the already established institutions can provide the same services and that we, therefore, do not need VICI. I say we have not allured them to our ivory towers and, therefore, we do need VICI.

I have mentioned the word education many times this afternoon and I hesitate to offend your intelligences by pausing to think over with you the meaning of the word from its Latin derivation educere, "to lead out", but I was reinspired when preparing for this afternoon by the words of George B. Leonard. He says:

Education is a process that changes the learner. And learning involves interaction between the learner and his environment and its effectiveness relates to the frequency, variety and intensity of the interaction.

It seems to me that you at VICI have found this secret. Your education will be community involvement. Your education is bound to place your students with frequency, variety, and intensity in relation to their environment. ✓ George Leonard, as you all know, finishes his definition with "Education is, at best, ecstatic." And this is the challenge of you at VICI. You somehow have an obligation to make learning not a burden but a joy, and not just a mild joy but an ecstasy - "a rapture of delight."

I envisage VICI as a place of non-elitism, a haven where all who wish to learn more will be welcome. We educators have (I believe this criticism to be just) created situations in which students lives have been fragmented. We have set the stage so that frequently the intellect is segregated from the emotions, formal education from reality. Historically, we have an interesting situation.

Arnold Toynbee traces the disintegration of the Chinese Empire under the Tsin and Han Dynasties and that of the Roman Empire in part to the attempt to extend formal education from the privileged minority to a wider circle. One reason, Toynbee says:

Was that the former privileged minority's traditional system of education was impoverished in the process of being disseminated. It degenerated into a formal education in book learning divorced from the spontaneous apprenticeship for life. In fact, the art of playing with words was substituted for the art of living.

This pitfall, with the involvement in the community VICI will avoid. We do no service when we lead the learner into the classroom away from life. I thought of VICI as I was reading an article by Phillip Boxxerman, the Research Director of the Center for Studies of Leisure at the University of South Florida. He says that:

True education means a place and structure wherein one finds his own level, his own interests, and measures himself. It is an intimate search for the truth in the give and take of dialogue, allowing one's curiosity to flower, learning from one another. It means learning in the human community, dispersed, decentralized.

This is the kind of education which, I believe, VICI can provide superbly.

And so I salute you today as you join us, the institutions with walls and I remind you that you are in the stream of a fascinating educational tradition. Vermont can boast of many successes and many firsts, we were among the first of the states to establish programs in teacher education we can boast of Justin Morrill and his part in the establishing of land grant colleges, to mention just two. And we rejoice as you join us, our state university, our state colleges, our private colleges and our community college in the great diversity which, if properly maintained is our greatest strength. And as I look up at the sky and think of the incommensurate amount of time educators have to spend on the problem of leaking roofs, I hope you always keep the sky as your roof. If it leaks, at least, you won't have to worry that it is defective.

I close with the hope that you will synthesize these purposely disparate thoughts and add them to your own on this important subject of education.

As I close, I personally wish you well, Steward, and all your associates and pledge my interest in all your endeavors. As I thought of this opening day, it seemed to me that you would gain strength from the words spoken by William Faulkner at the time of the presentation of the Nobel Prize. Faulkner said:

I believe that the award was made to my life's work, not for glory and least of all for profit, but to create out of the materials of the human spirit something which did not exist before. I believe that man will not merely endure, he will prevail. He is immortal not because he alone among creatures has an inexhaustible voice, but because he has a soul, a spirit, capable of compassion and sacrifice and endurance.

Sister Elizabeth Candon
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